

Human vs. AI Writing Identification

Annotation Scheme v1.0

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1. Introduction

This project investigates how well humans can distinguish between human-written and AI-generated essays. Large language models can produce writing that is coherent, resembling human writing. It is becoming increasingly difficult to distinguish between writing generated by AI and writing produced by humans.

For this annotation task, annotators read a set of essay excerpts and determine whether each text is more likely to have been written by a human or generated by AI. I will use the results to measure human agreement, identify ambiguous cases, and compare human judgments with the predictions of an automatic AI-detection model.

i. Annotation Goal

The goal of this annotation task is to evaluate how reliably humans can identify AI-generated writing. I will measure inter-annotator agreement between human annotators, identify texts that are difficult for humans to classify, and compare human judgments with model predictions. The results will provide insight into which types of writing are most challenging for both humans and models when distinguishing AI-generated text from human writing.

ii. Task Overview

Each annotator will be given a set of essays. For each essay, annotators should decide whether the writing is more likely to be written by a human or generated by AI, or indicated that they are unsure. Annotators will also provide a confidence rating indicating how confident they are in their decision. Each essay should be evaluated independently based only on the text provided. Annotators should not use external tools, search engines, or AI-detection systems while completing this task.

iii. Dataset

The texts used in this annotation task are from a collection of essay responses originally compiled for research on AI-generated writing detection. The dataset includes both human-written essays and essays generated by large language models in response to similar prompts.

The essays typically consist of short argumentative or explanatory responses to educational writing prompts. For the purposes of this annotation task, a balanced subset of texts was sampled from a held-out evaluation set.

To avoid biasing annotators, no information about the original source of each text is provided during annotation.

2. Google Sheets

Annotators will use Google Sheets to perform the annotation task. Each annotator will be given a link to a Google Sheets file, which will include 4 columns:

- id
- text
- label_guess
- confidence

For each row, annotators will read the text in the text column, then use the dropdown buttons in the label_guess and confidence columns to assign the labels.

Upon finishing the task, each annotator will contact me to let me know.

3. Annotation Labels

Each essay will receive one of the following labels:

- human
- AI
- unsure

i. Human-written essay

Select **human** if the essay appears more likely to have been written by a person. Human writing may show characteristics such as:

- distinctive voice or perspective
- uneven sentence structure or stylistic variation
- specific details or examples
- natural variation in tone or phrasing
- minor spelling or grammatical errors

These features are not required, but they may contribute to the overall impression that the text was written by a human.

ii. AI-generated essay

Select **AI** if the text appears more likely to have been generated by an AI system. AI-generated writing may sometimes display characteristics such as:

- fluent but generic language
- repetitive sentence structures or phrasing
- formulaic essay organization
- balanced but shallow discussion of a topic
- lack of specific or concrete details
- usage of the passive voice

These indicators are only guidelines, as no single feature determines whether a text is AI-generated.

iii. Unsure

Select **unsure** if you cannot confidently determine whether the text was written by a human or generated by AI. Use **unsure** when:

- both labels appear plausible
- the text contains mixed signals
- there is not enough information to make a reliable judgment

Do not use **unsure** simply because the essay is difficult to read or understand.

4. Confidence Rating

For each annotation, assign a confidence level indicating how certain you are in your decision. Confidence levels include:

- high - you are very confident in your judgment
- medium - your judgment is likely correct, but you are not completely certain
- low - you are only a little bit sure that you made the right guess

5. Annotation Procedure

For each essay:

- i. Read the entire text.
- ii. Decide whether the writing is more likely human or AI. If you cannot decide, you may label it as unsure.
- iii. Assign a confidence rating.
- iv. Record both values in the annotation sheet.

Each essay should be evaluated independently. Annotators should not attempt to balance their labels across the dataset.

6. Important Guidelines

When making your decision, base your judgment only on the text itself. Do not use external tools or AI detectors. Do not attempt to identify the dataset source or prompt. Treat each essay as an independent example. Both human and AI writing can be fluent, grammatical, and well structured. The goal is to make the best possible judgment based on the overall impression of the writing.

7. Disagreement

Disagreement between annotators is expected. Differences in judgment will be analyzed as part of the study. The goal of this annotation task is not perfect agreement, but rather to understand how humans interpret and evaluate AI-generated writing.

8. Examples

- i. Could you ever dream of never having to drive a car again? Well that dream might be closer to reality than you think. Recently Google and a bunch of other manufacturing companies have been trying to make that dream possible. They are invisioning a public transportation system. That they think would be more safe than having a human behind the wheel.

I would honestly love to live in a world where we didn't have to drive anymore. According to Google their semi-driverless cars would use half of the fuel a normal car would use. I mean come on who wouldn't like to same money on fuel. Now the only thing these cars lack are that they are not fully driverless. Which means you would still have to keep your hands on the wheel at all times incase you need to take control of the car.

How much would one of these cost? Imagine all of the equipment one of these cars have, and how expensive these cars would be? They have tons of sensors a rotating laser on the top of the car so it can locate its surroundings. Despite how expensive these cars are I think they would make the world a lot better. I mean if you have smarter roads and smarter cars then you wouldnt have to worry about accidents.

These cars have seats that viberate when their is an alert. Their is also a windshield display that will alert you as well. Before an error occurs the car will tell the driver when to take over. These cars would be much better on smarter roads. But when you look at it they would have to modify every road and thats to expensive fro reality.

So when it comes down to it I think driverless car would bea revolutionary product. That would change the world forever. I say we should do it, what do you think? Hopefully we will have them on the roads in a couple of years and they wont be as expensive as we think.

label_guess: human
confidence: high

- ii. I strongly believe that transitioning the traditional four-year high school education to a three-year graduation system would be beneficial, particularly for Latino students. I can personally attest to this, as a Latina Graham Fellow who graduated high school in three instead of four years. As someone who comes from a low-income family, I was able to save money and time by finishing my studies in a shorter period. Moreover, having the opportunity to expedite my studies has given me more time to pursue my higher education goals.

The accelerated education system could help give Latino youth a much-needed socio-economic boost by putting them on a faster track to success. Statistics show that less Latinos tend to attend college and to finish college than other population groups, and this is in part due to the economic barriers they face. With a three-year graduation system, they would be able to start their college careers earlier and increase their chances of achieving greater success in the long run.

On the other hand, the accelerated system could also be potentially detrimental to certain students. They might lack the skills and resources to keep up with such a demanding schedule and may struggle to adjust to the fast-paced environment. Additionally, some might feel pressured to complete their studies even if they are not ready, leading to deficiencies in their education and potential lower grades.

Ultimately, I think the three-year high school graduation system has the potential to be very beneficial. It could open doors for many Latino students who cannot afford to take four years to complete their studies. When done correctly, this accelerated educational system could positively impact the Hispanic community by providing them with the skills and resources needed to succeed.

label_guess: AI
confidence: medium

- iii. Have you ever wondered how your character is formed? John Lubbock once wrote, "Your character will be what you yourself choose to make it." I personally believe that our character is shaped by our environment, the people we surround ourselves with, and the values we hold dear.

Many people believe that we choose our own character by being true to ourselves and not caring what others think. However, I believe that our environment plays a significant role in shaping our character. For example, if we are constantly surrounded by negative people who always complain and see the worst in everything, we may begin to adopt their mindset and become negative ourselves. On the other hand, if we are surrounded by positive, supportive people who encourage us to pursue our dreams and passions, we may become more optimistic and confident in our abilities.

Another factor that influences our character is the people we surround ourselves with. Our friends, family, and peers can either support or hinder our personal growth. For example, if we surround ourselves with people who are constantly critical and judgmental, we may become defensive and closed off. On the other hand, if we surround ourselves with people who are supportive and encouraging, we may become more open-minded and empathetic.

Lastly, our values and beliefs also play a significant role in shaping our character. Our upbringing, education, and life experiences all contribute to the values and beliefs that we hold dear. For example, if we are raised in a household that values honesty and integrity, we may become more truthful and trustworthy in our interactions with others.

In conclusion, while we may have some control over the choices we make, our environment, the people we surround ourselves with, and our values all play a significant role in shaping our character. It is important to be mindful of the people we surround ourselves with and the values we hold dear, as they can either support or hinder our personal growth.

label_guess: unsure
confidence: low